Model Policy Memos with Sources

INTL-I 522 Global Development · Policy Memo Workshop · October 12, 2026

Most memos written for real decision-makers are lightly sourced. Your memo has to do two things at once: read like a memo and support its claims with research (at least 15 sources, 7 of them by experts). The four briefs below, from the Center for Global Development's *White House and the World* series, do both. Each puts its recommendations up front, uses headings a busy reader can skim, and backs its claims with endnotes. As you read, look at how the evidence serves the argument instead of crowding it out.

Modernizing US Migration Policy for Domestic and Development Gains

Michael Clemens & Nabil Hashmi · Center for Global Development · 2015, updated 2016 · Migration & remittances

https://www.cgdev.org/sites/default/files/whw-migration.pdf

Look for: how peer-reviewed economics research (articles in the *Journal of the European Economic Association*, *Review of Economics and Statistics*, and *Population and Development Review*) is woven into short, readable paragraphs. About 15 sources in 14 endnotes, plus a Further Reading list.

Protecting Tropical Forests, Global Prosperity, and Climatic Stability

Frances Seymour · Center for Global Development · 2015 · Climate finance & pay-for-performance

https://www.cgdev.org/sites/default/files/whw-forests.pdf

Look for: the most heavily sourced of the four, with 48 endnotes drawing on *World Development*, *Science*, and *Nature Climate Change* alongside official and think-tank sources. Is it still a memo at this length? What would you cut to get it to four pages?

Bringing US Development Finance into the 21st Century

Ben Leo & Todd Moss · Center for Global Development · 2015, updated 2016 · Development finance institutions

https://www.cgdev.org/sites/default/files/whw-usdfc.pdf

Look for: a memo that worked. Its proposal for a US Development Finance Corporation became law in 2018. Its 15 endnotes rely on official data and statutes rather than academic research. What counts as an "expert" source for a question like this one?

Taking the Lead on Trade and Development

Kimberly Ann Elliott · Center for Global Development · 2015 · Trade policy & development

https://www.cgdev.org/sites/default/files/whw-trade.pdf

Look for: four crisp recommendations stated before the introduction, then a body that justifies each one in turn. It has 11 endnotes plus a Further Reading list.

Two cautions

- **Citation style:** all four briefs use endnotes. Your memo must use APSR in-text citations and a bibliography. Copy their structure, not their citation format.
- **Who gets cited:** notice how often these authors cite their own institution. Your expert sources should come from a range of independent researchers and organizations.